was attacked and its library vandalised by a large mob calling itself the Sambhaji Brigade, made up of members of the youth section of the right-wing Maratha Seva Sangh. In November 2016 the Sambhaji Brigade announced that it was to become a political party – open to all except Brahmins!

The abuse now regularly heaped on both homegrown and foreign scholars who write about Indian history serves as a warning to all that India's religious differences and rivalries are like so many powder kegs waiting for someone to light this or that fuse. Fear of the consequences has made an ass of the law as it now exists in India – for which Indians may thank or curse the British, depending on where they stand on the issue of free speech.

Fear of giving religious offence under the notorious Section 295A of the Indian Penal Code has made a mockery of Article 19 of the Indian Constitution, which gives all persons the right to freedom of speech and expression subject to 'reasonable restrictions'. It has led to a situation whereby vast tracts of India's known history are either placed off limits or simply tiptoed over. Any zealot can now silence a writer of fiction or fact by complaining that his religious feelings have been hurt.

Nor is this an issue that Indians south of the Narmada can feel complacent about, because this is precisely what happened to the Tamilian author Perumal Murugan in January 2015: he was forced to make an abject apology to a local pressure group which declared itself offended by something he had written four years earlier in a historical novel. They complained to the local authority, who ordered the novelist to apologise. Writers in India and abroad rallied to support Murugan but not a single Indian politician, to my knowledge, spoke out against this abuse of power and the threat to free speech it posed. The latest news is that in July 2016 the Madras High Court issued a judgment that there was nothing obscene in the novel. It went on to remind the